

End Time

A sequence of poems by
Rik Roots

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Dedicated to the people who wonder:
what happens after?

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Streetlamp Theatre

Maggie stands tall tonight.
She has nails for heels
and cloth around her hips
damp from the low cloud.

Cars slow, stop, inquire –
she ignores their chrome charm.
Maggie stands tall tonight.

Lads drunk on new tattoos
offer tatter-notes for favours.
She has nails for heels

and sees no reason to upgrade –
she shuts away the pretty faces,
keeps cloth around her hips.

And when the face she needs
arrives, wallet on chain
damp from the low cloud

she takes chrome from her purse
and fucks his chest with bullets.
Maggie stands tall tonight.

The Digger

I was on the losing end of three hands
of duff cards; each round a waste
of good cash after better. The line
of table chatter was stacking words
towards my exit: the struts of a door
and my shadow through it, walking away.

Perhaps the cut of my suit scared away
some guardian angels. The deft hands
that re-fizz my gin are yours, door
keepers for happier places. We waste
a glance between us, eye-white words
feeding each other the pickup line.

You breathe in my ear: "I can line
you up with something stronger, away
from the tables, yes?" Easy words
to your blood-wine lips, easy like hands
in a pocket tapping on change. I waste
no time, ditch the game. The door

mule-kicks back at my push; your door
swivels easy on its hinge. A tight line
of lights marks the shore – we waste
a moment to draw in salt air. Then away
to a different land, jungle hot: hands
meshed as tight as mosquito nets; words

possum-still as if hunted by jaguar; words
hurled from stormy lungs. When the door
clicks open, again, when strange hands
grab at my limbs, when a hemp line
tightens at my neck I am already away –
lost within some wormwood waste.

"Who are you?" Your probe is a waste
of our time: who am I? A set of words,
nothing more; a gambler, a drunk away
from his righteous wagon, a door
pusher, a grifter quick with a line;
a man who sees futures in many hands.

A rustle of hands picking through your waste;
a click on your phone line – who hears your words?
I'll knock on your door and take you away ...

Post-murder

I adore this stinking town. So many ways
to die. Tonight a lady shot her pimp.

"Didn't love me hard enough," she husked
when asked by a flashbulb jockey: *...why?*

There's beauty in trash: those shadows
of what was can snatch an ache of stories
from an un-holstered head. «Didn't love me!»

Her pimp is rich in coins; they clink and skit
across planks, sketch hearts in bloody lines
as he eases though my door, chest agape –
another type of love, he groans. Dead bills flap
as the corpse puddles to my desk: *"Let's chat."*

We sit across split pine in a cracked room in a city
stacked at the end of time like party garbage.
"You're dead," I tell him. *"Your case is closed."*

The man has sapphires for teeth. From the hole
in his chest he lifts his heart, its meat stopped:
*"She broke this; she breaks it still. I need you
to find her, save her, keep her heart whole."*

Casework

Like all happy things, my commissions come in threes. Who am I to complain? The first, the pimp, pays in stones from his jaw. They are good stones, not glass; if I knew a straight pawnbroker I could pay some rent – but hey?

"You should settle your liquor bill first," says Anj, she of the dark eyes and the darker lusts. I should pay her first – I can read the woman like a ripped-off pulp – but I need her to ask, beg me for back wages. Angels have to learn about tempers before they lose them, and my guardian ain't too quick to pick up the particulars of human failures. That lady's fallen, for sure, but not far enough. Not yet.

If this were a story Anj would sit outside my office door, keen to insult all who pass her mouth, her cusses reminding the world of the sins of small-time capitalists living the dream of private investigations. My place would be behind a desk piled with half-abandoned cases of men who cheat their girls swirled on the romance of roses and vows. Maybe a missing dog to track down to the pound to keep me in loose change. There would be a bottle of rye in my bottom draw. There would be a lost partner whose space opposite me could bleach my bones in pities and guilts. There would be a girlfriend tucked away somewhere, or an ex-girlfriend or – let's be honest here – a bum chum of the 'close companion' type to keep a flame for my lost morals.

Fuck that for a set-up.

The liquor ain't negotiable. Hey! It's the End Times – the news-sheets say it daily so it's gotta be true – and I lost my trick pelvis a while back; if you can't kiss your ass goodbye you might as well wrap your lips around something useful!

My second commission's a lost cat. Now there's a story to tell ...

The Case of the Man Who was Dead

Friday

"Come," she says. *"I'll show you
second hand"* and takes her palms
to her brow and pulls them wide:
walls crack to ooze a Levant
light around us, swirl us – here.

This hill has strange trees.
"Only three, today," she smiles,
*"I've watched them plant forests
some mornings."* A spring orchid
spires amid cups of blue bindweed.

I see shapes in the guttering sun,
watching, long shadows restored.
*"We could not go to him; we bore
witness instead, a child of whispers:
what monsters and martyrs we birthed!"*

Almond petals spot the dry dirt
white about our feet. From the vale
wafts a sharp citrus; from the city
call the chisel taps of hasty repair.
"Lost!" she murmurs. *"I cannot move!"*

Saturday

"How did you torment him?" I demand.

His face is huge: an ice-wall chin calving
berg-hair; each cheek a flat tundra,
fell-field pockets grey in the chill –
his eye-caves could house nations.

And as he smiles, I follow his mechanics –
oil and shape, twist and form, evolve
a frosted fret of recollections tight
across his blue lip. *"You should ask
the one who supplied my design, perhaps?"*

He talks in gusts of air released
from glaciers – a slow whisper of gas
recalling the histories of the world.

*"I charted the story of his message
and watched him scream, scream. Scream!"*

Sunday

*"Know this: he was a changed man
when he first returned – more solid
than the walls he walked through;
his words boiled love in my heart.
He wore his wounds like totems."*

She's changed, too. No longer
the little woman – scarf-bound,
lip-taut seeker, lost. She hunts
like she hires: with crisp bills
on wood she measures my worth.

These are good notes. I measure
my questions accordingly: who
and where, and how. Not why –
the curves of her black-sheen
calves suppress my need to know.

There's no noise outside, no wind
to swirl the street litter in dance,
no midnight trade, no dogs. *"He's late,"*
she tells me. *"The world can't sing out
its rattle-tunes if he won't come home."*

Nocturne

Know this: it was the death of sunlight and sky that drew me to this fresh rye distill. Copper clouds drew reasons to thoughts, and muscles don't obey my orders in such moods. I've been gripping the neck for a long while now, watching stars flick between heavens.

I wish for rain: can you smell the drops? They reek of cool transactions and the promise of ice in tumblers.

Each sputter appears like a revelation on the pane that separates the beyond from here. Dark they are, a spit of harsh muse laughing at the hope of bottled comforts, thoughtlessly sipped. The first drop was bronzed jaundice, I remember now, a prismatic gathering of this bastard city's urgent towers and spires into a single daylit farewell.

Can you see the drop on the pane sag? There's enough gathered now to rivulet a course through dirt. They witness me as I watch them stipple a braille poem across glass. The only word I can read is: fool!

Anj ain't got no time for drunks, not tonight. Before she leaves our heap of space that pretends to be our office, her blouse two sizes too tight and her skirt a pencil of innuendoes, she clears my garbage of empties – ten cents on returns. She slaps my cheeks for luck and marks my brow with a kiss.

Such a night lensed in the rain. I wish I could walk through the fresh chill of washed air, my sniper's guile wrapping mysteries around my flesh. I wish – I wish I could stand...

The Job

Nine strikes chime the length of the hall.
She steeples her ears, extends a length
of claw and, in good time, yawns – the reach
of jaw wide and sharp and languid. A slit of jade
checks for scurries in shadows; a slow swish
in the webs that cove the room's ceiling
speaks of open windows. She levers limbs
from the curl and, four paws to the point,
arches, tail tall: shiver; still. The fluff
of dreams flicks from her lobes, and a lick
of spit primes whiskers for work. All edges
in her domain shall be checked, all scents
renewed by cheek and chin and scratch –
a duty as old and deep as an Egyptian nap.

Joan

She hides herself in curtains. There's a ruck
of demons trapped in fractured air; they slick
at her skin. She keeps her charms close and ticks
her thumb on each: a shell; a feather plucked
from a crow, dead in the street's gutter. Why
does Hell hide in the eyes of strangers? When
did Satan settle on Joan's soul? But then
she knows there's evil everywhere: the sigh
of doors; a light-switch click; the quiet hymn
of unseen codes that cut across the cloud
and slit her hopes, her thoughts – she grips her shroud
of curtains, summons fibs and pseudonyms
and prays to silent saints that don't exist
to stop the skirl of pulsing words ...

Second Sin

He brings a harsh heat into the room;
stones among sand: *"You see me?"*

I nod, reach for the warm whisky
as he hunches down on the chair
with the snapped back, almond mouth
bitter within its shallow beard.

He says: *"I need a vengeance. My grave
has room for another, a brother
to lie in his furrow by my bones.
I can pay you in camels, or goats."*

The sun in my dull mirror, it hangs
off the broken window, bloods clouds,
marks a fall. From the street, a shout;
a coil of flamed headline; the bark
of a car. *"Am I your brother's seeker?"*

"These are good camels," he smiles,
"keen in the snout for water."

The Seer

Beyond the dock, a shamble of shacks
crates a life's worth of stories beneath
their slow-cooling corrugations. My path
does not belong here, though my feet
disagree: I have a question that no measure
of bourbon will answer. This one

tells fortunes, she says. Her back
steeps higher than her head; the sticks
in her hands speak of richer work
long lost like a cool morning breeze.

*"This is not your first turn on the Wheel,
child. Many times you've climbed,*

*slimed, from a woman's womb - and still
you search."* I yearn for a tall tumbler,

ice promised in alcohol to hold my mind
to her words: *"You know what I seek?"*

She murmurs coercions and mentions coin –
a dime for bread and insights. Already

the sun cancers the clouds in blood
and the nights in these alleys care
only for drunks. *"They say the end
of time has come,"* I tell her. She shakes
her head against her shrunk chest: *"True,
true. None shall be born again, thank God!"*

Intel

Guns do not rattle. They punch through bones
to jack a shoulder back, a wrestler keen to wrench
joints apart, then whisper: I have made you God.

He says to me: *"Happy is He who repays you for
what you have done to us; He who gathers up
your infants and dashes them against the rocks."*

I have no gun, nor son, nor daughter to place
upon this city's pyres. All I have is a ragged prophet,
a fist around an empty bottle, and some dry eyes.

My questions are not bullets to shatter facts
from faces. I let the air escaping my tongue
wash the dirt from the old man's despair: where
and when, and who told you this, and that, and
'I have another jar of the good juice for a guy
who has the know of passing whispers to his friends.'

He jerks his chicken-thin neck like a jailbird dodging
the noose: *"Yes, oh yes; the words of a whisperer
are like dainty morsels. I can set that table for you."*

The Momentary Meanings of Hugh

He knows the mirror lies.

It lied when he was six,
refused to catch the ghosts

who whispered at his ear
within its dull blue frame.

It lied when he was ten,
aching long whiles to draw

the bruises on his face
he'd earned in playground brawls.

Wrap it. Bag it. Box it?

Move it. Shift it out and gone!

It lied last night. It placed
the tears across her cheek

when there were none. Her smile
did not translate. He knows

this mirror lies: it shows
a stranger's life at him;

it curses him, this plane
of guilt and long regard.

Smash it ...? No. Ten

thousand lies still lie!

He knows the mirror must lie.

From the Ass's Jaw

"Do you believe in destiny?"

He's old, this one, blind
as he walks in the steps
of a child. His breath
smells sweet, brandy in flame;
his lungs buzz. I shake my head –

"We are what we do, no more."

He laughs. *"A harsh judgement
you place on my back; I have killed
many men. A child of the sun
can do no more than follow
the knots embraided in his hair."*

"I have no comb to change you!"

He knocks bills from the desk
as he leans to my face: I see
midnight enthroned in sockets.

"I chose to push the pillars,"
he says, *"cascade that stony sky –*

"I am a good judge. Are you?"

Crime of Passion

He is a cold witness, as chill
as a slip of rime on the lip
of a crisp new beer. For weeks

I chased his rumour, sharp alleys
un-vexed by daylight, garbage
mansions bearding freeway struts.

This shade sits easy in my office,
his lids half-cupped as eyes check
evidence stacks for entertainments.

"The whisper is you want some words."

My list of questions is as long
as the walk to the liquor store,
but the one I choose is short: why?

"Who asks?" As he tilts his head
to scratch his beard I spot hemp-weave
patterns scorched deep in his neck.

My stare flicks to the desk where lies
a Gideons, liberated from its hotel
drawer by the woman who hired me.

"I choked, and yet I breathe again."

His smile is quick and sad, a crack
of tooth between louse-lush fuzz ruddied
by the slant guttering of the sun.

I tell him of visions. I tell him
that night follows day and histories
walk the city's baked streets.

"He told me to do it." he says.

*"Anyone can get their hands and heels
nailed to some planks of wood!"*

His face whips close: I catch rust webs
of bust veins etched on eye-whites –
his lung-dust stills my tongue.

*"I loved him! I kissed him and when
our lips touched my name was seared
to the heart of every man alive*

*"and every child whelped after. I sense
my style beats within your chest
... you cannot afford my dogma!"*

The Fire and the Ice

Some nights I daydream of a life beyond the City. I have memories, a few of them true – or as honest as a half-sober mind can make them. There was a time before the End Times, know.

They remind me of paintings, those dreams, a cracked cere smeared over smiles and snarls. Has a painter ever captured the cramp of an empty belly? I asked Anj, once. She shrugged me an answer – it was one of those days she was done talking to me: a good day, that one, which ended in a settled bill from a grateful wife with a vindiction to complete.

Beyond the City the land is a crack of dirt and skeletons steeped in a drought of lost promises. Those who were once there lived amid the gaze of a harsh sun in the pomp of its endless summer; too hot to sleep, us kids would daze our way from shade to twilight, one missed hop-skip-step from clinker melanomas.

Yeah ... good times.

"You gonna finish the Lady's case? She's paid an advance." Anj has ice in her water; the chips rattle in the tumbler like ten dollar tokens on the bones table. "It's religious," I say. She smirks: "The dame must be desperate to bring it to you."

What can I do, but agree?

All of the world is this City, now. Every love's sigh a breeze through detritus, every tear a salt slick in another shot of tequila. Our City is a place where diamonds are cheaper than a slice of lime, where wine skims through sump oil and the best place to find ice is in the chest of a dead CEO.

"I love this City," I tell Anj. She smiles, teases my brow with a wipe of cold glass as she reaches into my pocket to liberate her wage.

Joe

Joe is invisible, again. He's lowered
his hood to set his face free, let breathe
the scabs and growths in his bones
that dapple his jaw, his brow, his smile.

Joe knows he's invisible: the reflex lack
of eyes that look back – tell; the turn
of necks to shop displays – confirm:
the street is his toy to play with now.

As Joe takes steps, his majestic shadow
flutters ahead, clearing crowds so he can see
the artful measures taken to distill desires
to needs: firestorm sales to end all sales.

Look at what offers have been set to tempt
the coins in his pocket! For Joe has a stench
of many pockets, which he is eager to empty
and fill – though suited clerks can't spot Joe

beyond the tattooed knuckles holding coins,
ready to spin coppers across counters. Still,
a wealthy hand of uncaught thefts is as good as
a face that fits, for a man who cannot be seen.

Legend

He says: *"I was not the first superhero
to stride lightquick from mountain to town:
sit close, seeker, and let us share words
worthy of curses and judgements."*

Gossip has drawn me to his artless nest
of chromed rusts set deep in this cleft
between skyscraped walls. Bee swarms
tress from his scalp - a strength of sorts.

"You should strangle angels with gifts,"
he tells me. *"What mother would deny
her own son the solace of wine, or beer?
I never sought power; yet I am here."*

Some call him Riddler; others whisper
of slaughters and bloodlusts. I have a gun
by my heart, its womb taut with bullets;
brass cases line the jaw of his ass.

*"That one you seek – he is lost and found
and lost again. Angels raped his mother,
you know? He read his eulogies, screamed
blood from his eyes. I was a judge, once,*

*"and rendered temples to their foundations;
you do not want to help that man. Salvation
is a fool's gamble, a fixed deal. I tell you now:
stars will shatter when he sets down his verdict."*

In Deo Speramus

They say it takes a thief to catch a diamond:
the stone I seek should spark like resurrections –
but not in this city of parvenu panhandlers, too busy
skimming the cream of solid work to sniff the sewer
they sit in. A long walk later I find my thief

stood in a tap room with ant-addled stools:
*"Can't abide the scrub of them splinters on my arse,
if you can savvy me."* I oil him in gin to part his lips:
"You know where he is?" He has a slow, long smile
and a longer nod – *"I sees him around. He peeps*

*through them holes in his hands, that one,
not keen to hold to his promises. But I knows
him well, his smells and shakes. I shares
his fame like we shared that hill for a time –
he's quiet, mind: worries his head for our world;
he won't scream no more for this dead making."*

Case Notes

The trouble with sobriety is the tendency to think clearly – I mean: who needs that shit? This bastard city makes more sense when my edges are smoothed.

Take this canal. Last night it was a stretch of shoddy water along which I could amble and sit and roll up into its bank for a few moment's peace. But now I'm awake and clean with the shakes all it offers is a bunch of recollections: friends and fathers and Happy Times and a headache from Hades itself.

Did I really go visit Hell? That giant was cold, man! A face of eternal ice chips begging for a hot bourbon ocean to melt in.

I don't know what's real no more. I made notes; they're in my pocket somewhere. Don't need no beermat scribbles to know I've gone crazy – dead pimps don't walk into my office and show me their fucking hearts! Anj would've mentioned the mess, bless here flint-sharp soul!

I have a thirst that could drink buckets from this canal. Even after I've pissed in it.

This man the Lady wants me to find is everywhere and nowhere. Look in a shattered window, a garbage-fed flame – the chrome sheen of a gun's barrel – he's there, waving back. Taunting me: catch me if you can, old man!

Who is he? All the revenants know him. One fucker kissed him and another died with him on a hill. I could die right here: the way my temples throb they might as well house a couple of friendly-fire slugs. And when I find him – what then? It's the End Time, baby! Settle my businesses; pay poor Anj the last of the wages I owe her. Curl my head to my thighs and kiss my lame cock goodbye!

And then what – this whisper of a man gets to judge me? Whatever.
I've been judged by two myths already: the third'll be the fucking charm.

I'm gonna find him, today. I know this in my churned guts. I already
have my defence planned: *Please Have Mercy, Your Immanent Honour, For I
Do Like Cats.*

The Warrior

There is no chill to the mists that lap
between the bars of this cage. The man
I seek sits on the gate's step, his neck
chained in the bones and nails of thumbs
and toes. His teeth are flint, his torso
a marble of sweat and soot and vein.

*"Are you here to beg, or fight? I see you can
count to ten: an unholy edge in this game."*

Beyond the steel arena litter pits flicker
with new-sprouted flame; shadows
of a crowd clot in huddles, their murmurs
a purr of anticipations. A drum of moonshine
fountains when a pick bites its purloined lid.
I ask about heroes with holes in their hands.

*"He brawls like a wildfire, that one. His haul
of sliced trophies near matches my own."*

The cage is small, six paces to a side
and barely a hop to grasp the bars
that span its roof. The floor is a mud
of blood; I can read screams in the slide
of foot-stamps. Hair mats the gate's hinges.
An eye has spat its cataract onto the lock.

*"The rabble here, they love his lethal dismay;
I have his number, if you have the moves."*

In the Airless Night

A man asked me today: *did you ever love him?* And I had to, to think ...

Perhaps when I was young and clever
I found space in my heart for one
whose stories echoed through decades –
a hero of sorts, a brother who
came here to an earth ripe with promise
and penance. Tales he gave us, ways
made fit for those who despaired of fitting
their wrecked lives to some norm beyond
the reach of their kibbled coins. A holy,
deserving man of the lord come
to deliver riches and solace: loving
each other the key to joy – *did I
ever love him?* Where others saw angels
I saw a book full of old words
and angels were harsh fairies with trumpets
and wings too big for their, their frocks ...

They nailed him hard to wood, poor bastard,
then bowed to his tattered meat – if that
is love, then no: I refuse to worship
a butchered corpse, the ghost it hatched
or any lie his, his acolytes created ...

Some people say he lives again,
that this is the promised time of raptures:
ungather us from evil men
indeed! Yet others whisper: he rages
and sobs and screams at what we've done,
become in his name. Seek out this spirit
fleshed again against his will
and stop him before he shatters the heavens
and peels the clouds to cleanse the world
in lightning and ice. People are hatreds –
now there is a love I understand,
for sin is my heart, my joy and my comfort,
my wealth and hearth, solace and, and lust ...

To the man who spoke to me this morning:
I'm sure when we meet, our love shall burn!

Death of a Poem

They dragged it from its rank cell tied to a bookshelf bier, its bondage spun from old glue-spattered twine. It tried to lay flat in its frame, but the morning was dank with low cloud; jeers flapped at its long-ago turned corner, lifting it as if a salute. The plank was heavy: it parted each puddle in a wake to shod onlookers in mud. They responded with hawked spits and rancid fruits – a tatter-tape celebration of its forthcoming demise.

Slow was that journey, yet quickly done. Its i's widened as the wood to which it was tied stood on its end, and flew.

Above the crowds, space. Across the platform it could see the tortures of its demise: string; board; crayon and scissors. Declamations were made, but it didn't listen. It worried about its last words, though it knew its last words already – a good couplet, rhymed, with a brief epiphany signalled in syllables. Words and shape were its entirety: what else could there be?

First the hanging, pegged by its bottom margin to a washing line and pulled up, and up to where the wind could ripple its papery flesh. One of its words was 'flag', it realised. Now it was a flag, white with fright, alone since that day it had been ripped from the loving leaves of its tribe and taken to the hall of hollow echoes, for judgement. Another of its words was 'map': the map is not the thing, it knew, yet now it was.

Only after a severe gust tore into its flat weave was it lowered. A hand reached up and plucked it roughly from the pegs, leaving its beloved page number – eighty four – stranded in air. No time to hurl vowels to the sky. The hand screwed it to crushes before patting it flat on the board and applying brass tacks to keep it pinioned. Which colour would they use? it found itself wondering, again. An ink of classroom green was its worst fear, an analytical dissection of its form and function in front of bored kids only

there for the attendance mark. It almost sighed when the fat red crayon pushed into its title to be dragged from corner to corner, bent corner to missing corner – the very X of communication.

The last act – the final torture whose mere fact had wormed through its fibres during the nightmare hours - was a relief when it came. This executioner was called Stanley, according to the brand stamped into its hash-grip handle. A fine blade, honed to peak perfection – the cuts that gutted lines to words, words to letters, were a lover's caress, a mother's soft stroke.

In the crowd below, a girl in tears recites its verse from memory. It doesn't matter. Today is a day for petals and confetti: released, it can litter the world.